

On being photographed

Week 9 Lecture 2 , Looksmaxxing: Evidence-Based Self-Improvement

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Why camera height matters more than any other variable
- Three-quarter vs. straight-on: which framing works for most faces
- Natural light vs. ring light: what each does to a face
- Micro-adjustments that read as natural, not posed
- Updating your weekly progress photos with better technique

Camera height and angle

The single most impactful variable

The lens position relative to your face changes the apparent shape of your jaw, forehead, and neck more than lighting, posing, or post-processing.

Rule: lens at eye level or very slightly above. Never below.

Why it matters (Mango Street, 2020): "The most flattering angle for most faces is slightly above eye level. It reduces the under-chin area, lengthens the neck, and gives the jawline more definition. The worst angle is below eye level, which does the opposite of all three."

This applies to your phone selfie, your profile photo, and your weekly progress shots.

What happens below eye level

When the lens is at chest height or lower:

- The forehead appears larger relative to the jaw
- The nose appears wider and longer
- The under-chin area (submental fat) is highlighted and compressed
- The neck appears shorter

This is not opinion. It is the predictable result of perspective distortion: a wide-angle or standard lens placed below the subject elongates nearer features relative to farther ones.

The fix costs nothing: hold the phone at eye level or above.

Above vs. at eye level

Slightly above (5-10 cm): the classic flattering portrait position. Jawline reads sharper, neck reads longer.

Directly above (bird's eye): the face looks round and the body disappears. Useful for some contexts, not for progress tracking or professional photos.

For weekly progress photos, consistent is more important than perfect. Pick a height, mark it on the wall, and use it every week.

Framing and turning

Three-quarter vs. straight-on

Straight-on framing shows the full width of your face and is the standard for passport photos and driver's licenses. It works well if your face is narrower or has clear cheekbone definition.

Three-quarter framing (body and face turned 45 degrees from the camera) does three things:

- Narrows a wider face by showing it at an angle
- Shows the jaw and cheekbone in a single view
- Creates depth by making near features appear larger than far ones

For most faces, three-quarter framing is more flattering than straight-on. The difference is most visible in photos taken at medium to close range.

Applying the three-quarter turn

The turn is subtle. Do not turn your body 90 degrees and look back at the camera over your shoulder. That looks posed.

Instead:

- Turn your body 30-45 degrees away from the camera
- Turn your head back toward the lens until your nose is pointing roughly at the camera
- Keep your chin slightly forward and down (not tucked hard, just not pulled back)

This is the “posing without posing” principle from *Mango Street* (2020): the adjustments are there, but they should not read as effortful.

Lighting

Natural light: why it works

Soft natural light from a window or open doorway is diffused by the atmosphere and by the window glass. It wraps around the face and fills shadows rather than creating them.

The rules:

- Face toward the light source, not away from it
- 45-degree angle to the source is the classic three-quarter portrait lighting
- Direct overhead natural light (noon outside) is harsh; move to shade or face a wall that reflects light back

Natural light is free and available. If you have access to a north-facing window or open shade, you already have a better setup than a ring light.

Ring lights: what they actually do

A ring light placed directly in front of the face produces flat, even illumination with catch-lights visible as rings in the eyes.

What it does well: reduces blemishes and shadows by eliminating contrast.

What it does poorly: flattens facial structure. The same shadows that can seem unflattering in harsh light are what give the face depth and make features readable. A face lit entirely evenly looks two-dimensional.

Ring lights became popular for video calls, not for photography. For weekly progress photos, a window is better.

Avoid harsh overhead light

Overhead-only lighting (typical indoor ceiling lights at night) creates:

- Strong under-eye shadows
- Deep nose shadow pointing downward
- Harsh highlight on the forehead and nose tip
- Under-chin shadow that emphasizes submental fullness

If you can only shoot at night with ceiling lights: angle yourself under the light so it is slightly in front of you rather than directly above. Or add a lamp at face level.

Micro-adjustments

Posing without posing

The goal is to look like yourself at your best, not to look posed. Posed photos read as posed.

Three adjustments that do not look like adjustments:

1. Push your chin forward and slightly down. This tightens the submental area and defines the jaw. It should feel slightly exaggerated; it reads as natural.
2. Roll your shoulders back and down before the photo is taken. Then let them relax. They land in a better position than your default.
3. Turn your body slightly away from the camera and look back into the lens. This creates breadth across the shoulders and draws the viewer's eye toward the face.

Practice these in a mirror. They become automatic within a few sessions.

Updating your weekly photos

Week 2 established your baseline. Now is the first time you apply better technique to the same format.

Keep these constants from week 2:

- Same location, same background
- Same clothing (or same state: shirt or no shirt)
- Same distance from the camera

Add from this week:

- Camera at eye level (mark the wall if needed)
- Soft frontal light (face the window)
- Three-quarter turn for one of the three shots

Consistency enables comparison. Better technique enables the photo to show what is actually there.

Take-aways

1. Lens below eye level is the single most common photo mistake. The fix costs nothing: hold the phone at eye level or higher.
2. Three-quarter framing narrows a wider face, shows the jaw, and creates depth. Straight-on works for narrower faces with strong definition.
3. Soft natural window light beats ring light for progress photos: it preserves facial structure while filling harsh shadows.
4. Three micro-adjustments: chin forward and down, shoulders back before relaxing, slight body turn with head toward the lens.
5. Consistent setup enables comparison. Better technique enables accurate tracking.

“The most flattering angle for most faces is slightly above eye level. It reduces the under-chin area, lengthens the neck, and gives the jawline more definition. The worst angle is below eye level, which does the opposite of all three.”

Rachel Gulotta & Daniel Inskeep, Mango Street (2020)

What is next

- **Section:** Film yourself standing and walking. Self-review and peer-review. Take your updated weekly photos.
- **Reading:** Week 9 reading includes a full worked example of the three photo setups as ASCII diagrams.
- **Next lecture:** Week 10, Lecture 1: Body dysmorphia, comparison, and the looksmaxxing rabbit hole.
- **Assignment due:** HW4 (Five-look capsule wardrobe) is due this week.